

# Career Incentives and Research Topic Choice Among Economists

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## **Abstract**

Do economists who study sensitive topics such as race, religion, discrimination, and gender, face career penalties, and do they respond by strategically shifting their research agendas around tenure? This paper constructs a novel dataset linking dissertation topic choices from the JEL Annual Dissertations Lists (1990–2024) to post-PhD career outcomes from IDEAS/RePEC. Preliminary descriptive evidence from the 2024 cohort shows that women are substantially more likely than men to write dissertations on sensitive topics, particularly at top PhD programs.

# 1 Introduction

- Academic economists face strong incentives to publish in top journals and secure tenure.
- Research on sensitive topics (race, religion, discrimination, gender) may be harder to publish or perceived as less rigorous, creating career risk.
- This paper asks: (1) Are economists who study sensitive topics penalized in their careers? (2) Do they strategically shift research agendas around tenure?
- I use the JEL Annual Dissertations Lists to track dissertation topic choice from 1990–2024 and link to career outcomes via IDEAS/RePEC.
- Preliminary evidence: women are substantially more likely to write sensitive-topic dissertations, especially at top programs.

# 2 Literature Review

- [Ginther and Kahn \(2004\)](#): women less likely to receive tenure in economics even conditional on productivity.
- [Bayer and Rouse \(2016\)](#): overview of underrepresentation of women and minorities; structural barriers in the profession.
- [Card et al. \(2020\)](#): evidence of gender bias in peer review at top journals.
- [Hengel \(2022\)](#): papers by women take longer through peer review and are held to higher standards.
- [Doleac and Pancotti \(2022\)](#): documents who researches race and policing; notes underrepresentation of minority scholars.
- [Koffi \(2021\)](#): women more likely to pursue novel and unconventional research, which may carry higher career variance.
- [Akerlof and Michailat \(2018\)](#): career incentives can distort research choices and perpetuate existing paradigms.

# 3 Data

- **JEL Annual Dissertations Lists**: published annually in the *Journal of Economic Literature*, available on JSTOR. Contains dissertation title, author name, institution, graduation year, and JEL codes. Sample: 1990–2024.

- **Sensitive topic classification:** dissertation flagged as sensitive if title contains keywords related to race, ethnicity, religion, gender, or discrimination, OR if JEL codes include categories such as J15, J16, Z12. Formally:

$$S_i = \mathbf{1} [\text{title}_i \in \mathcal{K} \cup \text{JEL}_i \in \mathcal{J}] \quad (1)$$

where  $\mathcal{K}$  is the keyword set and  $\mathcal{J}$  is the set of sensitive JEL codes.

- **Career outcomes:** IDEAS/RePEC provides publication records, citation counts, and institutional affiliations. Merged to dissertation records using author name, institution, and graduation year with fuzzy matching.
- **Current status:** 2024 cohort parsed and analyzed. Full 1990–2024 merge in progress.

## 4 Empirical Strategy

- **Cross-sectional:** estimate gender gap in sensitive-topic dissertation choice, with cohort and program fixed effects:

$$S_{ic} = \alpha + \beta \text{Female}_{ic} + \gamma \text{TopProgram}_{ic} + \delta (\text{Female} \times \text{TopProgram})_{ic} + \theta_c + \varepsilon_{ic} \quad (2)$$

- **Career outcomes:** regress publications, citations, and placement rank on sensitive-topic indicator, controlling for gender, program rank, cohort, and field:

$$Y_{ic} = \alpha + \beta S_{ic} + \mathbf{X}'_{ic} \gamma + \theta_c + \lambda_p + \varepsilon_{ic} \quad (3)$$

- **Research agenda shift:** event-study around expected tenure year ( $\approx 6$ – $8$  years post-PhD), testing whether sensitive-topic researchers reduce their share of sensitive publications approaching tenure.
- Key identification challenge: separating genuine preference change from strategic self-censorship.

## 5 Results

- Women are substantially more likely than men to write sensitive-topic dissertations in the 2024 cohort (see Table 1).
- This gender gap is largest at top-10 and top-20 programs (see Figure 1).

- Gap persists across all sensitive subcategories; largest for gender-related topics.
- Sensitive-topic dissertations concentrated in labor economics and development economics.
- *Longitudinal career outcomes results pending completion of IDEAS/RePEC merge.*

## 6 Conclusion

- Preliminary evidence points to a large gender gap in sensitive-topic dissertation research, particularly at top programs.
- Next steps: complete IDEAS/RePEC merge for 1990–2024 cohorts; estimate career penalty and research-agenda-shift specifications.
- If sensitive-topic research is penalized, the profession may be systematically under-producing knowledge on some of the most policy-relevant questions.

## References

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## Figures and Tables

Table 1: Summary Statistics: 2024 JEL Annual Dissertations List

|                           | Men | Women |
|---------------------------|-----|-------|
| Total dissertations       | [N] | [N]   |
| Share sensitive topic (%) | [x] | [x]   |
| Top-10 program (%)        | [x] | [x]   |

*Notes:* Data from 2024 JEL Annual Dissertations List. To be populated with actual values.

Figure 1: Gender Gap in Sensitive-Topic Dissertations by Program Tier, 2024

*Notes:* Share of dissertations classified as sensitive, by gender and program tier. Figure to be inserted once R output is finalized.